

Smart Glasses > Phones ?

Over the past two decades, smartphones have dramatically reshaped our lives, becoming indispensable for communication, navigation, entertainment, and countless other everyday tasks. Yet, increasingly, voices at the top echelons of the tech world suggest that the smartphone era, at least as we know it, may soon be coming to an end. Mark Zuckerberg of Meta, Andy Jassy of Amazon, and even Apple's Tim Cook have all hinted strongly at an impending shift toward wearable technology, particularly augmented reality (AR) glasses.

The underlying rationale for these claims is evident. Smartphones, despite their capabilities, demand constant physical attention—users must look down, disengage from their surroundings, and interact through tactile screens. Smart glasses promise a markedly different experience: hands-free interaction seamlessly integrated into everyday life, allowing users to remain fully engaged with their physical environment while still accessing digital information. Voice control, gesture recognition, and eye-tracking technologies have matured significantly, making AR glasses a feasible alternative to phones.

Notably, industry leaders have openly articulated their visions. Mark Zuckerberg, whose company Meta has heavily invested in AR and VR, sees smart glasses as the logical successor to the smartphone, believing they will become the standard medium through which digital content is consumed. Amazon's Andy Jassy also pointed to ambient computing—ubiquitous, voice-activated digital assistance—as the core future tech model, a perfect complement to wearable devices like AR glasses. Similarly, Apple, which transformed consumer technology with the iPhone, is also rumoured to be developing advanced AR glasses, quietly aligning its long-term strategy to pivot from smartphones to wearable tech.

The beginning of this transition seems imminent, with major launches scheduled for late 2025 and early 2026. Meta's Project Nazare a.k.a. Orion aims to deliver sophisticated AR capabilities within sleek eyewear, while an updated version of Ray-Ban Stories glasses is also on the horizon. Amazon, reportedly



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working on its own glasses, is expected to integrate Alexa's extensive ecosystem, positioning AR glasses at the core of a seamless digital experience. Apple, notoriously secretive yet consistently transformative, appears poised to unveil AR glasses with aspirations similar to its groundbreaking iPhone.

Other major tech players like Google, Xiaomi, and Huawei are equally invested in this emerging market. Google's previous experiments with Google Glass were perhaps premature, but the lessons learned and technology evolved position them to re-enter the market at the right moment. Chinese tech giants, already experienced with wearables, see smart glasses as an extension of their ecosystems, potentially capturing significant market share globally.

However, this revolutionary transition will not occur without hurdles. Privacy remains a substantial concern—smart glasses, equipped with cameras and sophisticated tracking technologies, pose new and complex privacy issues. Users and those around them must negotiate new social norms about where and when such devices are appropriate. Furthermore, significant technical challenges persist. Battery life, processing power, heat management, affordability, and aesthetic appeal must improve substantially before widespread adoption is achievable. Also, each of these devices cost thousands of dollars and are produced in extremely limited quantities. It will be well over a decade before smart glasses become more prominent than smartphones, if at all.

Regulatory frameworks also present potential roadblocks. Authorities worldwide will scrutinise how smart glasses handle personal data and user security. Manufacturers must proactively address these concerns to avoid the backlash faced by earlier wearable tech attempts, such as Google Glass.

Despite these challenges, the shift from smartphones to smart glasses is inevitable. Beyond a new device, it's about fundamentally altering how we interact with digital information and the physical world around us. Over the course of the next decade, the ubiquity of smart glasses could redefine human experience, even as smartphones take a back seat. **d**